

Social housing

The cramped slum housing in Europe's 19th-century cities, a legacy of the Industrial Revolution, led to generations of ill-health and high infant mortality in working families. In 1919 the British government, facing a severe housing shortage, passed an act to subsidize council building programmes. By 1921, some 170,000 low-density houses – with three bedrooms, indoor toilets and a garden – had been built for the better-off working classes. Across Europe, architects including Gropius, Taut and Martin Wagner (1885–1957) designed practical, low-cost housing solutions, with low-rise flats reaching Britain by the late 1920s. But the heavy bombing of the next war led to an even greater housing crisis. Britain's response was to throw up some 156,000 'prefabs' – short-lived, factory-built bungalows – followed by hardier homes of reinforced concrete. In the 1950s, with homes still scarce, architects now envisioned a new style of mass social housing: tower blocks, or 'streets in the sky', with communal facilities such as crèches and laundries. By the 1960s, more than 500,000 tower-block homes were built in London alone.



Karl Marx-Hof in Vienna, Karl Ehn, 1927–30